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SYLLABUS

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

The Complete *Exam Guide*

Paper 1 Reading and Paper 2 Directed Writing & Composition — every question, what it tests, and exactly how to answer it.

- ◆ All 4 Paper 1 questions
- ◆ Step-by-step answer frameworks
- ◆ Timing plans for both papers
- ◆ Command words decoded
- ◆ Both Paper 2 sections
- ◆ Worked examples & model lines
- ◆ Top 10 mark-losing mistakes
- ◆ Exam-week revision checklist

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How to use this guide

This guide is built for students sitting Cambridge IGCSE First Language English (0500) from June 2027 onwards. The exam was restructured for 2027, so older revision guides and many past papers no longer match the questions you will actually face.

Work through it in three passes. First, read the **Exam at a Glance** so you know the shape of both papers. Second, study one question at a time: read the framework, then try it on a past or specimen paper. Third, in exam week, use the **timing plans**, the **mistakes list** and the **checklist** to sharpen technique.

01	The exam at a glance — and what changed in 2027	3
02	Paper 1 · Question 1 — Comprehension	4
03	Paper 1 · Question 2 — Summary task	5
04	Paper 1 · Question 3 — Short answers & language task	6
05	Paper 1 · Question 4 — Extended response to reading	8
06	Paper 2 · Section A — Directed writing	9
07	Paper 2 · Section B — Composition	11
08	Command words & timing plans	12
09	Top 10 mark-losing mistakes	13
10	Exam-week revision checklist	14

CHECK YOUR ROUTE

Every candidate takes Paper 1. Most then take Paper 2; some schools enter students for the Coursework Portfolio (Component 3) instead. Ask your teacher which you are taking. This guide covers Papers 1 and 2.

The exam at a glance

Two written papers, each **2 hours**, each **80 marks**, each worth **50%** of your grade (A*–G). No dictionaries. Texts are printed in a separate insert.

Paper 1 – Reading

Three texts (A, B, C), about 1,400 words in total. Four compulsory questions, 20 marks each. Spend about 15 minutes reading first.

Question	Text	What you do	Marks
Q1 Comprehension	A	Short answers on explicit and implicit meaning	20
Q2(a) Summary	B	Selective summary in your own words, max 120 words	15 (10R + 5W)
Q2(b)	B	Short answer on attitudes and opinions	5
Q3 Short answers	C	Sub-questions, including word meanings in your own words	10
Q3 Language task	C	Writer's effects, about 200–250 words	10
Q4 Extended response	C	Letter, report, journal, speech, interview or article, 250–300 words	20 (10R + 10W)

Paper 2 – Directed Writing and Composition

Answer one question from each section.

Question	Text	What you do	Marks
1(a)	1–2 texts 550–650 words	Structured question: analyse and evaluate the text(s), including how the writer influences readers	5
1(b) Directed writing	Same	Discursive / argumentative / persuasive speech, letter, article or report, 250–350 words	35 (10R + 25W)
Section B Composition	None	One of four titles (2 descriptive, 2 narrative), 350–450 words	40

WHAT CHANGED FOR 2027

- Paper 1 now has **four questions of 20 marks each**. Question 1 tests all five reading skills.
- The summary question gained a **new 5-mark part, 2(b)**, on attitudes and opinions.
- Word-meaning questions in Q3 are now worth **2 marks**, and key words appear in **bold** (no longer underlined).
- Shorter writing targets: language task 200–250 words; Q4 250–300 words.
- Paper 2's reading texts are shorter, and directed writing is split into **1(a)** and **1(b)**. For the first time, Paper 2 tests how writers influence readers.

Question 1 – Comprehension

A series of short sub-questions on Text A. Some ask what the text *says* (explicit); others ask what it *suggests* (implicit). The marks in brackets tell you how many separate points to make.

The framework: Find → Prove → Phrase

- 1 **Find.** Underline the key word in the question, then locate the exact lines. Questions usually follow the order of the text.
- 2 **Prove.** For "explain" or "suggest" questions, go one step beyond the words on the page: what does this detail tell us about the person, place or situation?
- 3 **Phrase.** Answer in your own words unless the question says "give a word or phrase" or "quote". One clear point per mark.

EXPLICIT (SAYS)

"Give two reasons why...", "Identify...", "What does the writer tell us about..."

The answer is stated. Be precise; do not add commentary.

IMPLICIT (SUGGESTS)

"What does this suggest about...", "Explain how the writer feels..."

The answer is implied. State the inference, then anchor it to a detail.

Worked example

EXTRACT

Ravi arrived forty minutes early, pressed his tie flat for the third time, and read the company's mission statement on the wall until the words stopped meaning anything.

Question: What does this sentence suggest about how Ravi feels before his interview? [2]

WEAK ANSWER • 0–1

He arrived forty minutes early and pressed his tie flat.

Copies the text and never says how he feels.

STRONG ANSWER • 2

He is very nervous (1) and anxious to make a good impression (1), shown by his repeated, restless checking of his appearance.

EXAMINER-STYLE TIP

Count the marks and give exactly that many distinct points. A 3-mark question answered with one long idea still scores 1.

Question 2 – Summary task

2(a) Selective summary **15 marks** **max 120 words**

You select only the information that answers the question's focus, and write it as **continuous prose in your own words**. Reading earns 10 marks; writing (clarity, organisation, concision) earns 5.

- 1 **Lock the focus.** Rewrite the question's focus as a heading, e.g. "Problems faced by first-time volunteers".
- 2 **Harvest points.** Read Text B and number every relevant point in the margin. Ignore examples, statistics and anecdotes unless they *are* the point.
- 3 **Group and merge.** Combine related points under one umbrella word ("they face practical *and* emotional challenges").
- 4 **Write it once, tightly.** Aim for 100–115 words, no introduction, no conclusion, no opinions.
- 5 **Check.** Count words. Cross out any phrase copied directly from the text.

DO

- Use your own vocabulary
- Link ideas with connectives
- Cover the whole text
- Stay in the third person

DON'T

- Lift whole phrases
- Write in note form or bullets
- Add your own views
- Go over 120 words

Turning text into your own words

Text says	You write
"Many newcomers find the early mornings exhausting and quit within weeks."	Early starts wear out many beginners, who often give up quickly.
"There is rarely anyone on hand to explain what needs doing."	They frequently lack guidance or supervision.

2(b) Attitudes and opinions **5 marks**

A new short-answer question on Text B. It asks what the writer (or someone in the text) thinks or feels, and how you can tell. Structure each point as **attitude + evidence + brief explanation**.

MODEL LINE

The writer is sympathetic towards volunteers: calling them "quietly heroic" presents their effort as admirable even when it goes unnoticed.

Question 3 – Short answers & language

20 marks • Text C

Part 1: Short-answer questions 10 marks

Sub-questions of different lengths on Text C, testing explicit meaning, implicit meaning and how the writer creates effects.

Word-meaning questions (now 2 marks each). Words appear in **bold**. Give the meaning *in context*, in your own words.

- 1 Read the whole sentence the word sits in, plus the one before.
- 2 Write a short meaning that fits this exact context.
- 3 Test it: swap your meaning into the sentence. Does it still make sense?

EXTRACT

The storm had left the harbour **desolate**: boats overturned, nets abandoned, not a voice to be heard.

WEAK

Sad.

Too vague; misses the emptiness.

STRONG

Empty, deserted and bleak.

Part 2: Language task 10 marks 200–250 words

You analyse how the writer uses language to create effects in specified paragraphs of Text C. This rewards **precise selection and close explanation**, not a list of techniques.

The framework: Choose → Zoom → Connect

- 1 **Choose** 3–4 powerful short choices from each paragraph named in the question. Single words and short phrases work better than long quotations.
- 2 **Zoom** in on individual words: their literal meaning, then their connotations (the feelings and images they carry).
- 3 **Connect** to the effect on the reader: what picture or mood is created, and why the writer wants it.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Never write "this creates vivid imagery" or "this makes the reader want to read on" without explaining *what* image and *why*. The explanation is where the marks are.

Language task — worked example

EXTRACT

The market woke before the sun. Shutters clattered upward like startled birds, and within minutes the lane was a river of voices, carts and colour. Old Farida sat at its centre, still as a lighthouse, watching the tide of buyers break around her stall.

WEAK ANALYSIS

The writer uses a simile, "like startled birds", which creates vivid imagery. The metaphor "a river of voices" also makes it interesting and makes the reader want to read on.

Labels techniques but never explains the image or its effect.

STRONG ANALYSIS

The market is brought to life as a single waking creature: it "woke before the sun", suggesting an energy that begins before the day itself. The shutters "clattered upward like startled birds": "clattered" gives a sudden, harsh noise, while "startled" suggests the rush of movement is almost panicked, as if the market has been shaken awake. The "river of voices" shows how the crowd flows as one continuous, overwhelming current, so the reader feels swept along. Against this movement, Farida is "still as a lighthouse". A lighthouse is fixed, calm and watchful, so she seems a steady, experienced figure the busy crowd must "break around", like waves against rock. The writer contrasts chaotic motion with her stillness to make her seem powerful and timeless.

Useful phrases for explaining effect

To explain meaning	To explain effect
"...suggests that..."	"...so the reader feels..."
"...carries connotations of..."	"...emphasising how..."
"...implies..."	"...creating a sense of..."

STRUCTURE YOUR 200–250 WORDS

One paragraph per section of text named in the question, 3–4 choices in each. Finish with one sentence on the overall impression the writer creates.

Question 4 — Extended response

You write 250–300 words in a given form (letter, report, journal, speech, interview or article), usually in the voice of a character or someone connected to Text C. Reading and writing earn 10 marks each.

The framework: Mine → Stretch → Voice

- 1 **Mine.** The task gives two or three bullet points. Find every relevant detail in Text C for *each* bullet. Treat each bullet as its own mini-question.
- 2 **Stretch.** Top answers go beyond retelling: they develop ideas, make reasonable inferences and draw conclusions that are rooted in the text.
- 3 **Voice.** Write convincingly as the given person, in the given form, for the given audience. Match tone and register.

Form conventions at a glance

Form	Must include	Tone
Letter	Greeting, clear purpose in opening, sign-off	Formal or informal to suit recipient
Report	Title, short subheadings, recommendations	Objective, clear, formal
Journal	First person, date or time, reflection	Personal, honest, emotional
Speech	Address audience, direct appeals, strong close	Engaging, rhetorical
Interview	Clear speaker labels, developed answers	Natural but purposeful
Article	Headline, engaging opening, paragraphs	Informative, lively

THE BIGGEST TRAP

Retelling Text C in order with a greeting stuck on top. Examiners reward selection and development, not a copy with a new heading.

PLANNING IN 5 MINUTES

Draw three columns, one per bullet. Fill each with 3–4 details from the text, then add one inference per column. Write only when every column has content.

Section A — Directed writing

40 marks

One or two texts (550–650 words in total) present ideas and opinions on a topic. You first answer a structured question about them, then use them to write your own discursive, argumentative or persuasive piece.

1(a) Structured question 5 marks

Tests whether you can analyse and evaluate the texts' ideas and explain how the writer tries to influence readers. Keep answers short and focused.

- Name the writer's view or technique precisely.
- Support with a brief quotation or reference.
- Explain how it works on the reader, or judge how convincing it is.

MODEL LINE

The writer uses a striking statistic, "one in three teenagers", to make the problem seem widespread and urgent, though she never says where the figure comes from, which weakens her argument.

1(b) Directed writing 35 marks 250–350 words

You write a speech, letter, article or report. **Reading earns 10 marks:** you must use, develop and *evaluate* the ideas in the text(s). **Writing earns 25 marks:** style, structure, vocabulary, audience awareness and accuracy.

- 1 Decode the task.** Note form, audience, purpose and your position. Circle them.
- 2 Map the texts.** List the key arguments in each text. Mark each one: agree, disagree or "yes, but...".
- 3 Evaluate.** Question the texts: Is there evidence? Is it biased? What is left out? Evaluation is what lifts reading marks.
- 4 Plan 4–5 paragraphs.** Hook opening, three developed arguments drawn from the texts, clear conclusion or call to action.
- 5 Write and check.** Stay in 250–350 words. Save 3 minutes to proofread.

Directed writing — making it evaluative

The difference between a mid-level and a top-level response is rarely vocabulary. It is whether you **engage critically with the texts** instead of repeating them.

Level of engagement	What it sounds like
Repeating	"The article says that homework causes stress."
Using	"Homework can cause stress, as many students report working late into the night."
Developing	"This stress matters because tired students learn less the next day, which defeats the purpose of homework."
Evaluating	"Yet the article relies on a single survey of one school, so we should be cautious before banning homework altogether."

Evaluation starters

- "While the writer claims..., this overlooks..."
- "This argument is persuasive because..."
- "The evidence here is limited to..."
- "Both writers agree that..., but they differ on..."
- "A fairer view would recognise that..."
- "If this were true, we would expect..."

Persuasive toolkit (use with purpose, not as a checklist)

Device	Example
Direct address	"You have felt this too, haven't you?"
Rule of three	"tired, distracted and discouraged"
Counter-argument + rebuttal	"Some say...; however..."
Emotive contrast	"not a burden, but a lifeline"

AUDIENCE DECIDES REGISTER

A letter to a head teacher and an article for a student magazine can argue the same point but should sound completely different. Show the examiner you know who you are writing for.

Section B — Composition

Choose one of four titles: two descriptive, two narrative. All 40 marks are for writing: content and structure, plus style and accuracy.

Descriptive: paint a picture

- **No plot needed.** Resist making things happen.
- Build a convincing sense of place through close observation.
- Vary your focus: wide view → close detail → wide again.
- Use all five senses and fresh, precise imagery.
- Consider one extended metaphor to hold the piece together.

DESCRIPTIVE STRUCTURE

1. Establishing view
2. Zoom to a detail
3. A person or movement
4. A shift (time, weather, mood)
5. Return to the wide view, changed

Narrative: tell a story

- A clear, developed plot with one central event.
- Few characters, fully drawn.
- Build tension towards a climax; avoid rushing the ending.
- Show, don't tell: reveal feeling through action and detail.
- Keep tenses consistent.

NARRATIVE STRUCTURE

1. Hook (in the middle of action)
2. Context and character
3. Complication
4. Climax
5. Resolution or twist

Upgrading a sentence

Basic	Upgraded
The room was very old and dusty.	Dust lay over everything like a grey eiderdown, softening the corners of a room no one had loved in years.
I was scared when I heard the noise.	The sound came again, closer. My hand froze on the door handle.

SPEND 10 MINUTES PLANNING

The best compositions are planned. A clear structure and a strong ending matter more than squeezing in extra words.

Command words & timing plans

Command words decoded

Word	What it means for you
Analyse	Examine in detail: show the meaning and how the parts work together.
Evaluate	Judge the quality, importance or value of something.
Explain	Give reasons, say how or why, and support with evidence.
Identify	Name, select or recognise. Keep it brief.
Give	Produce an answer from the text.
Describe	State the main points or features.
Suggest	Put forward a reasonable idea where several answers could be valid.
Justify	Support a case with evidence or argument.

Paper 1 timing (120 min)

Read all texts	15 min
Q1 Comprehension	20 min
Q2 Summary + 2(b)	25 min
Q3 Short answers + language	25 min
Q4 Extended response	30 min
Final check	5 min

Paper 2 timing (120 min)

Read texts + 1(a)	15 min
Plan 1(b)	8 min
Write 1(b)	35 min
Plan composition	10 min
Write composition	45 min
Final check	7 min

MARKS = MINUTES

Each Paper 1 question is worth the same 20 marks. Do not let one question steal time from the next.

Top 10 mark-losing mistakes

#	Mistake	Fix
1	Copying phrases straight from the text	Plan in your own words first; use umbrella terms.
2	Ignoring a bullet point in Q4	Treat each bullet as its own mini-question and plan for all of them.
3	Adding ideas that aren't in the text	Ask: "Where does it say or imply this?" If you can't point to it, cut it.
4	Naming techniques without explaining them	Zoom into the word, explain its connotation, then its effect.
5	Poor timing	Use the timing plans; move on when time is up.
6	Stuffing the summary with examples	Main points only; stay under 120 words.
7	Summarising the texts in directed writing instead of evaluating them	Question the evidence, weigh the arguments, give your own reasoned view.
8	Writing a story for a descriptive title	Description needs atmosphere and detail, not plot.
9	Word meanings that don't fit the context	Swap your meaning back into the sentence to test it.
10	Slipping tenses and careless punctuation	Proofread every piece slowly in your final minutes.

REMEMBER

Most lost marks come from technique, not ability. Fix these ten habits and your grade can rise without learning a single new word.

Exam-week revision checklist

Paper 1 — Reading

- ☐ I know the four questions and their marks
- ☐ I can tell explicit from implicit questions
- ☐ I give one point per mark in Q1
- ☐ I can write a summary under 120 words in my own words
- ☐ I can explain a writer's attitude with evidence (2b)
- ☐ I test word meanings in context
- ☐ I can write 200–250 words of close language analysis
- ☐ I plan Q4 in three columns, one per bullet
- ☐ I know the conventions of all six Q4 forms

Paper 2 — Writing

- ☐ I can answer 1(a) briefly and precisely
- ☐ I evaluate texts, not just repeat them
- ☐ I can write a speech, letter, article and report
- ☐ I adjust register to the audience
- ☐ I have practised both a descriptive and a narrative piece
- ☐ I can plan a composition in 10 minutes
- ☐ I stay within the word ranges
- ☐ I proofread for tense and punctuation

The night before

- ☐ Re-read the timing plans
- ☐ Re-read the top 10 mistakes
- ☐ Pack pens, a watch and water
- ☐ Sleep

A FINAL WORD

You do not need to be a born writer to succeed in this exam. You need a method for every question and the discipline to use it. You now have both. Good luck.

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